

Art & Design

Year 9 · Student Course Book

Every child is an artist. Keep the studio open.

Year 9 art and design develops making, looking and thinking: drawing, colour, print, 3D and the artists who changed how we see.

INSIDE THIS BOOK

- Skills: drawing, paint, print, 3D
- Artists and movements in context
- Sketchbook habit and portfolio building
- Critique language and reflection
- Final project per unit

IMPRINT

EDITION	First edition, 2026. Printed in full colour on white stock.
PUBLISHER	Prime School Press is the publishing imprint of Prime School, Portugal.
RIGHTS	© Prime School 2026. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system or transmitted in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the publisher.
CREDITS	Editorial Board. Pedagogical Academic Group · Pedagogical Team · Pedagogical Department · Content Creation Team. Written and typeset in the Prime School Press studio, Lisbon.
CURRICULUM	Cambridge Lower Secondary Art & Design (0073), Stage 9. Ages about 13 to 14.
LICENCE	It is an independent publication and is not an official Cambridge Assessment International Education or Oxford University Press publication.

Independent publication. This is an independent publication produced by Prime School for use within its own programmes of study. It is not affiliated with, licensed by, endorsed by or approved by any examination board, or by any other publisher.

Ages 13 to 14 · Lower Secondary

www.primeschool.pt

Welcome

This book is your student course book for Year 9 Art & Design.

You will use it in class to look, think, experiment, make and keep evidence of your thinking. It is not only a reading book and not only a colouring book. It is both: places to understand ideas, and places to draw, write and reflect.

Path for every topic:

READ → LOOK → THINK → DISCOVER → TRY → CREATE → REFLECT

Welcome to Year 9 Art & Design

Art is everywhere.

It can be found in paintings and sculptures, but also in photographs, films, buildings, clothes, posters, illustrations, objects, digital images, installations and the spaces around us. Sometimes art is carefully planned. Sometimes it is spontaneous. Sometimes it is beautiful. Sometimes it is strange, uncomfortable, confusing or even difficult to understand.

You already know how to make images. Year 7 trained looking and the visual elements. Year 8 trained portrait, architecture and the design brief. Year 9 asks a harder question: why you make a particular choice, and what that choice communicates.

Art and Design is not only about drawing well or producing something that looks attractive. It is about observing, questioning, interpreting, experimenting, making decisions and communicating ideas. Through experimentation and reflection, an uncertain starting point can become something much more developed.

Artists do not simply ask: “How can I draw this?” They also ask:

- What am I trying to communicate?
- Why have I chosen this subject?
- What am I trying to say?
- What choices could I make?
- What happens if I try something different?

These questions are at the heart of artistic practice.

How artists work

Most artists do not jump straight to a final masterpiece. A common studio cycle is:

1. Notice something (an object, a feeling, another artwork, a place).
2. Collect (sketches, photos, notes, material tests).
3. Try (rough versions, mistakes, surprises).
4. Choose (what to keep, what to change).
5. Refine (improve control, composition, meaning).
6. Share (show, title, explain).
7. Reflect (what did I learn?).

Warm-ups that look wrong can still be excellent practice. Neatness is not the same as learning.

Contents

Introduction	5
Unit 9.1 · Still Life	11
Chapter 1 Introduction to still life	11
Chapter 2 Observational studies	14
Chapter 3 Media experimentation	17
Chapter 4 Artist research	18
Chapter 5 Composition development	19
Chapter 6 Final still life outcome	20
Chapter 7 Review and project completion	22
Unit 9.2 · Identity	23
Chapter 1 Introduction to identity	23
Chapter 2 Image gathering	24
Chapter 3 Portrait and symbolic studies	26
Chapter 4 Media experimentation	28
Chapter 5 Image manipulation	29
Chapter 6 Artist research and analysis	30
Chapter 7 Composition planning	31
Chapter 8 Final outcome development	32
Chapter 9 Review and project completion	33
Unit 9.3 · On the Surface / Contained	36
Chapter 1 Theme introduction	36
Chapter 2 Mind maps and mood boards	37
Chapter 3 Visual recording	38
Chapter 4 Artist research	39
Chapter 5 Media exploration	41
Chapter 6 Image development	41
Chapter 7 Composition planning	42
Chapter 8 Final outcome development	43
Chapter 9 Review and project completion	44
Unit 9.4 · Exhibition	46
Chapter 1 Selection of work	46
Chapter 2 Portfolio review	47
Chapter 3 Presentation planning	48
Chapter 4 Artist statement	50
Studio pages · Look, try, reflect	54
Techniques 1-5 · Watercolour to acrylic	58
Appendix · Reference	63
A Visual elements	64
B Principles of design	66
C Art & Design vocabulary	67
D Artists, designers and references	69
E Assessment and success criteria	70
Notes	71
Sources	72

By the end of Year 9 you can

- observe carefully and record what you see
- use the visual elements intentionally
- experiment with a variety of materials and techniques
- analyse the work of artists and designers
- understand how artists communicate ideas and emotions
- develop personal responses to themes
- manipulate and transform images
- explore abstraction and simplification
- make decisions about composition
- refine ideas through experimentation
- explain and evaluate your artistic choices
- work with increasing independence
- present your work as part of a coherent portfolio

From Year 8 to Year 9

Year 8 trained portrait, architecture and the design brief. You learned to look at faces as structure, buildings as designed objects, and posters as communication with a job to do.

Year 9 does not throw that away. It asks you to use it with more independence.

Year 8 habit	Year 9 move
Draw the face correctly	Decide how much of a person to show
Shade the building	Turn a surface into an idea
Answer a design brief	Write part of the brief yourself
Copy an artist's look	Borrow a strategy and make it yours
Finish a piece	Curate a group of pieces

If you are still waiting for the teacher to tell you when a drawing is “done”, this is the year to practise finishing for a reason.

What does it mean to think like an artist?

Artists do not simply ask: “How can I draw this?”

They also ask:

- What am I trying to communicate?
- Why have I chosen this subject?
- What does this image make me feel?
- What could this object represent?
- How can colour change the meaning of an image?
- What happens when I remove information?
- Can an ordinary object become visually interesting?
- How can I make the viewer look at something differently?
- What can I communicate without using words?
- What happens when I combine two apparently unrelated ideas?

These questions are part of artistic thinking.

There is often no single correct answer in Art & Design. However, there are stronger and weaker decisions. A strong artist is able to make decisions, test them, recognise when something is not working and make changes.

Year 9 is the year you practise that independence. Your teacher will still demonstrate, still set briefs, still keep the room safe. The thinking, though, has to become yours.

Think like an artist

Pick one ordinary object from your bag or pocket. Write three completely different intentions for making an artwork about it: one about memory, one about design, one about a feeling. Which intention would change the composition the most?

write three intentions for one object

Your sketchbook is a visual laboratory

Your sketchbook is not simply a place where you keep finished drawings.

It is your visual laboratory.

You should use it to:

- collect images
- record observations
- make sketches
- test materials
- experiment with composition
- annotate your ideas
- analyse artists
- record successes and failures
- develop alternatives
- reflect on your progress

Do not be afraid of mistakes.

A page containing experiments, corrections and unsuccessful attempts can be more valuable than a page containing one carefully copied drawing.

Treat the sketchbook as evidence of thinking. A future teacher, an examiner, or next-year-you will care as much about how an idea grew as about the final piece.

Do	Avoid
Date every page	Waiting for a "perfect" first page
Label tests (blind contour, close-up, clay fragment)	Throwing away "ugly" warm-ups
Stick in tickets, textures, photos, fabric	Only copying finished internet images
Write short notes in your own words	Copying long biographies
Record what failed and why	Pretending every page is a final



IMAGE 0.02 - A working sketchbook. Purpose: show process pages (tests, notes, observations) rather than only finished drawings.

Remember

Neatness is not the same as learning. An honest failed experiment, labelled, is better evidence than a page that looks finished and says nothing.

Looking is a method

Looking is not the same as seeing. We see thousands of things every day, but we do not always really observe them.

When you draw from observation, you are not simply copying an object. You are learning to notice proportion, relationships, subtle changes in colour, light and shadow, surface, movement, negative space and unusual viewpoints.

When you look at an artwork, move through five stages. Year 7 and Year 8 used a four-step look. Year 9 adds evaluate and respond, because you are now expected to take something into your own work.

1. DESCRIBE. What can you actually see? Name colours, lines, shapes, objects, materials, scale. Do not interpret yet.
2. ANALYSE. How has the artist organised the visual elements? Think about composition, contrast, viewpoint, surface.
3. INTERPRET. What might the work mean? What feeling, idea or question does it suggest? Give a reason.
4. EVALUATE. What is successful or interesting? What would be weaker if it changed?
5. RESPOND. What quality will you borrow as a strategy, not as a costume? What will you try this week?

A useful way to look

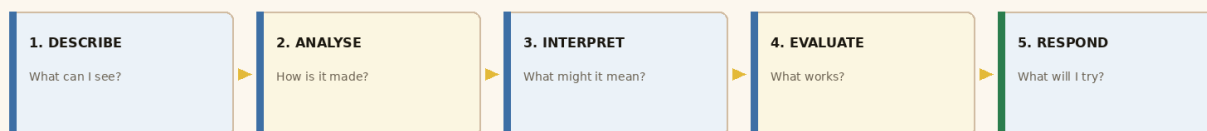


IMAGE 0.03 - A useful way to look. Purpose: five steps from description to a personal response.



IMAGE 0.04 - Memory versus observation. Purpose: compare a simplified memory sketch with a careful observational study of the same bottle and apple.

Practical task: look twice

Choose one object on your table. Draw it from memory for two minutes. Then draw it from observation for eight minutes. Write one sentence: what did looking change?

left: memory 2 min · right: observation 8 min

How to use this book

This book is both a reading book and a making book. You will see the same kinds of boxes in every unit. Learn them once.

Box	What it is for
On the desk	The mood of the lesson
By the end you can	The destination, not a shopping list to tick blindly
Think like an artist	A question with no single right answer
Your turn	A making task that fits the lesson
Challenge	Stretch, if you finish or if you want more risk
Curiosity / Did you know?	A checked fact. Use it; do not decorate with it
Careful	Health, safety, respect, ethics
Key words	Vocabulary to use in annotations
Reflect	Honest evaluation, not "I like it"

Draw in the dashed boxes. If you run out of space, continue in the sketchbook and tape a thumbnail here.

Photograph work that will be painted over, fired, taken home or installed.

Classroom expectations

In Art & Design, the way you work is as important as the final outcome.

You are expected to:

- arrive prepared and ready to work
- bring your sketchbook and required materials
- use equipment responsibly
- respect other people's work
- keep your workspace organised
- follow health and safety instructions
- clean materials and work areas after use
- listen during demonstrations
- use lesson time effectively

- participate in discussion and critique
- give constructive feedback
- take responsibility for your own development

Year 9 critique is not a talent show. It is a way of making the next decision. When you speak about someone else's work, name a visual fact first ("the crop cuts the bottle at the shoulder") and then a possible effect ("it feels more tense"). Avoid "I like it" unless you can say why.

Materials and safety

Year 9 uses a wider range of processes: drawing media, paint, pastel, collage, cameras, print, clay and mixed media.



IMAGE 0.05 - Studio materials. Purpose: introduce the range of tools used this year.

Studio kit

Keep ready	Why
HB, 2B, 4B, 6B pencils	map, mid-tone, dark tone
charcoal and putty rubber	soft tonal drawing; lift lights
fine liner / brush pen	contour, continuous line
watercolours or gouache, palette, water pot	colour studies
soft pastels or oil pastels	surface and contrast
A4/A3 cartridge + sketchbook	tests and finals
scissors, glue, collage papers	identity and surface units
camera or phone camera	visual research (with permission)
clay, board, modelling tools	masks, fragments, vessels
viewfinder (card window)	crop compositions
cutting mat	safe cutting



IMAGE 0.06 - Working safely. Purpose: cutting mat, organised table, liquids away from electrical equipment.

Health and Safety

Art materials and equipment must always be used responsibly.

- follow teacher instructions when using tools and materials
- carry sharp tools carefully, point down, and use them on a cutting mat
- do not use materials in ways for which they were not intended
- keep liquids away from electrical equipment and cameras
- wash hands after using pastels, clay, inks and adhesives
- keep floors and tables free from bags and unnecessary materials
- report accidents or damaged equipment immediately
- ask before photographing people; some classmates will not want their face in a picture

Safety is part of professional artistic practice.

Did you know?

The phrase still life in English is a translation of the Dutch stilleven: "still" as in motionless, not "still" as in continuing. A still life is not an uninteresting life. It is an arrangement that holds still long enough for you to look.

A studio process

You will not use this sequence as a cage. You will use it so you can notice when you have skipped a stage.

A Year 9 studio process



IMAGE 0.07 - A Year 9 studio process. Purpose: observe, research, explore, experiment, develop, refine, create, reflect.

Artists often discover what they want to say by experimenting rather than knowing the answer before they begin.

The most important question this year is no longer only "Can I make this?"

It becomes: "Why do I want to make this, and how can I make the viewer understand it?"

That is the beginning of becoming an independent artist.

Unit 9.1 - Still Life

A still life is a work of art showing non-living objects. These items can be natural, like fruit and flowers, or man-made, like books and cups. The word comes from an old Dutch term meaning quiet or stationary life.

Common subjects

Natural things: fruit, vegetables, plants, shells and cut flowers. Man-made things: books, vases, glasses, coins and pots. Symbolic items: skulls or candles, used to show that life is short.

Why artists paint still life

Focus on basics: artists study colour, shape and how light hits an object. Freedom: objects do not move, so artists can take their time arranging them. Hidden meanings: some pieces send messages about wealth, time or death.

On the still-life desk today

A glass bottle, a pear, a paperback, a house key, a cloth, a lamp.

Your teacher says: "Do not start by making it pretty. Start by asking what the group of objects could be about."



IMAGE 9.1.01 - Still-life studio. Purpose: set the materials and mood for Unit 9.1: looking, arranging and painting objects.

In this unit you will

- choose objects for meaning, not only for appearance
- compose with viewpoint, overlap, crop and empty space
- draw from observation using line, tone and texture
- test pencil, paint, pastel and mixed media
- research artists as strategies, not as pictures to copy
- develop thumbnails before a sustained outcome
- evaluate whether the final work communicates your intention

Chapter 1 - Introduction to still life

Why arrange objects at all?

A pile of shopping on a table is not yet a still life. A still life begins when someone decides.

You decide which objects belong together. You decide what is in the foreground. You decide where the light comes from. You decide what is cropped out of the frame. Those decisions are already a kind of thinking.

In the Dutch Golden Age, a breakfast piece might show bread, a pewter jug and a lemon. The objects were ordinary. The painting was not: it could speak about plenty, time, or the shine of a surface that will not last. You do not have to paint a skull to talk about time. A browning apple and a stopped watch can do it.



IMAGE 9.1.02 - Objects that can carry meaning. Purpose: an original arrangement of fruit, book, bottle, watch and key as possible symbols, not a copy of a famous vanitas.

Composition

Composition refers to the way visual elements are organised within an artwork.

Consider:

- Where is the main object?
- What is in the foreground?
- What is behind it?
- Where does the eye move?
- Are there areas of empty space?
- Are objects overlapping?
- Is the composition balanced or deliberately unbalanced?
- Where does the light come from?

A strong composition is not necessarily symmetrical.

Sometimes visual tension is created by placing an object close to the edge, using an unusual viewpoint or leaving a large area of empty space.

Composition choice	Possible effect
Centred, even space	calm, formal, presentational
Cropped at the edge	tense, contemporary, incomplete on purpose
Bird's-eye	map-like, designed, less "window"
Low viewpoint	objects become monuments
Overlapping cluster	relationships, crowding, family of things
Large empty field	quiet, lonely, or Morandi-like stillness

Think like an artist

If you move the bottle 4 cm to the left, does the meaning change? Try it with real objects before you draw.

sketch: same objects, two different compositions

The visual elements as tools

You will use line, shape, form, tone, colour, texture, pattern and space.

Try to think of these elements as tools, rather than isolated concepts.

Tone can create volume. Texture can communicate the difference between glass, metal, fabric and fruit.

Negative space can be as important as the object.



IMAGE 9.1.03 - Visual elements in a still life. Purpose: one study using line, volume, colour, texture and negative space on bottle, spoon, linen and fruit.

Artist references: four strategies, not four costumes

Study how artists have used still life differently. Compare artists who use realistic observation with artists who simplify, distort or abstract objects.

Ask:

- What objects have they selected?
- Why might those objects have been important?
- How have they arranged them?
- What is the role of colour?
- How is light used?
- What mood is created?
- What makes the work recognisable as a still life?

Year 9 uses four strategies. Steal the strategy. Do not copy the picture.

Artist	Strategy you can use
Giorgio Morandi (1890-1964)	Repeat humble bottles and boxes. Mute the colour. Let small shifts of interval become the subject.
Paul Cézanne (1839-1906)	Build fruit and cloth from planes. More than one viewpoint can sit in the same picture.
Clara Peeters (active c.1607-1621)	Everyday food and metalware. Look for tiny self-portraits reflected in a jug: the artist is inside the still life.
Juan Sánchez Cotán (1560-1627)	Hang vegetables in a dark window. Dramatic light, almost mathematical space.
Michael Craig-Martin (b. 1941)	Everyday objects as clear outlines and unexpected colour. Design thinking inside still life.
Lisa Milroy (b. 1959)	Objects in a grid. Repetition turns stuff into looking.



IMAGE 9.1.04 - Four still-life strategies. Purpose: original teaching arrangements for quiet bottles, constructive fruit, dramatic cellar light, and outline objects.

Curiosity

Clara Peeters included her own face, tiny, reflected in the polished metal of jugs and cups. A still life can contain a self-portrait if you know where to look. That is a useful Year 9 idea: the maker can hide inside the objects.

Practical task: choose for meaning

Select five objects from the studio or from your bag. Arrange them so the group could be titled Waiting, Inheritance or After school. Photograph the arrangement. Write the title first, then draw.

arrangement + title: Waiting / Inheritance / After school

Watch me work one out

Inês empties her bag onto the still-life table: a tram ticket, a pear from lunch, a house key, a blue pen, a scuffed rubber.

First idea: draw everything. That is a pile, not a still life.

She removes the pen and the rubber. She keeps the ticket, the pear and the key. Title: After school. She puts the pear in front, the key half-hidden under the ticket, and the lamp to the left so the ticket casts a long shadow. The shadow does more work than a second pear would.

She makes four thumbnails and keeps the cropped one, because After school should feel slightly too late, slightly cut off.

That is a Year 9 decision: fewer objects, a title, a light source, a crop.

Key words

still life · composition · symbolism · viewpoint · negative space · vanitas · interval

Chapter 2 - Observational studies

Before developing a final still life, you need to learn to observe.

Observation is different from drawing what you think an object looks like.

When drawing from observation, look carefully at proportions, angles, contours, negative spaces, light, shadow, surface, texture and relationships between objects.

Line

Experiment with different types of line: continuous line, broken line, contour line, expressive line, directional line, cross-contour line.

Do not automatically outline everything.

Sometimes an edge can be communicated through a change in tone rather than a drawn line.

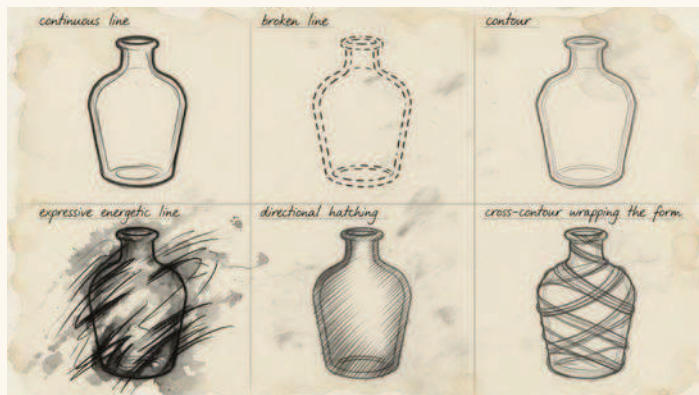


IMAGE 9.1.05 - Types of line. Purpose: the same bottle described with continuous, broken, contour, expressive, directional and cross-contour line.

Practical task: line library

Make six small drawings of the same object, changing only the kind of line. Label each one. Which line feels most honest to the object? Which line feels most like a mood?

six line studies of one object, labelled

Tone

Tone describes the range from light to dark.

Look for highlights, mid-tones, cast shadows, reflected light and deep shadows.

Avoid shading everything evenly.

Think about where the light is coming from and how it affects each surface. Glass collects highlights. Cloth swallows them. A lemon has a core shadow that turns.



IMAGE 9.1.06 - A tonal map. Purpose: highlight, mid-tone, core shadow, reflected light and cast shadow on a jug and lemon.

Texture

Texture can be actual or visual.

Actual texture can be physically felt.

Visual texture is created to make a surface appear rough, smooth, shiny, soft or hard.

Experiment with marks that communicate different surfaces.



IMAGE 9.1.07 - Four surfaces. Purpose: glass, metal, linen and fruit peel as visual texture.

Challenge: edges without outlines

Draw a still life using almost no contour line. Let tone and texture invent the edge. If you get lost, squint until the object becomes a puzzle of lights and darks.

tonal still life: edges made of tone, not outline

Think like an artist

When does a drawing stop being a picture of "a bottle" and become a picture of light?

write your thinking

Key words

observation · contour · cross-contour · highlight · core shadow · reflected light · visual texture

Chapter 3 - Media experimentation

Different materials produce different visual languages.

The objective is not to use as many materials as possible.

The question is: Which material best communicates the quality or idea I want?

Pencil

Explore pressure, hatching, cross-hatching, blending, erasing and directional marks.

A 2B maps. A 6B states a dark. An eraser is a drawing tool: it pulls light back out of graphite.

Paint

Consider transparency, opacity, brush marks, layering, colour mixing, and controlled versus expressive application.

Watercolour can leave the paper as highlight. Gouache can sit on top like enamel. A dry brush can become linen. A loaded brush can become a shine.

Pastel

Explore soft transitions, strong marks, blending, layering, texture and contrast.

Pastel dust is a surface. Fixative changes it. Do not blow pastel towards anyone's face.

Mixed media

Combining materials can create unexpected results: pencil + paint; pastel + collage; ink + watercolour; drawing + photographic elements.



IMAGE 9.1.08 - Four media, one subject. Purpose: graphite, gouache, pastel and mixed-media versions of the same bottle and fruit.

Pastel, paint and collage

Share water pots. Do not wash acrylic or gouache into a sink in lumps. Keep pastel work away from wet paintings. Collage adhesive wrinkles thin paper: test on a scrap.

Practical task: same object, three media

Choose one object. Make a 15-minute study in graphite, a 15-minute study in paint, and a 15-minute study in pastel or mixed media. Annotate which material said "glass" or "cloth" most clearly.

three media / one object / notes

Challenge: let one process change another

Draw in ink, then wash colour over it, then collage a photograph of the same object on top, then draw back into the collage. Stop when the original object is still sensed but no longer politely described.

ink → wash → collage → drawing back in

Key words

hatching · opacity · transparency · tooth · mixed media · visual language

Chapter 4 - Artist research

Artist research should go beyond collecting images and writing biographies.

The purpose of research is to understand how another artist thinks and works.

When analysing an artwork, use the Year 9 method:

Stage	Question
Describe	What can you see?
Analyse	How has the artist used visual elements and composition?
Interpret	What might the work mean?
Evaluate	What is successful or interesting about it?
Respond	What can you learn from the artist and apply to your own work?

You should not simply copy an artist's style.

Instead, identify a particular quality that interests you and experiment with it in your own work.



IMAGE 9.1.09 - A research page. Purpose: images, swatches, notes and a small study. Research is thinking, not collecting.

How to write about an artist without copying a website

Paraphrase. Name the work, the date if you have it, and the source. Then write what you notice.

Weak: "Morandi was a famous Italian painter who painted bottles."

Stronger: "Morandi repeats a family of bottles until the gaps between them feel as important as the objects. I am going to try a limited grey-green palette and three vessels only."

Practical task: one artist, one quality

Choose one quality from one artist in this chapter (interval, planes, reflection, hanging objects, outline, grid). Make three small experiments that use that quality on your objects.

three experiments from one borrowed quality

Look further (ask a teacher or family adult)

Tate's still-life glossary is a clear starting point: <https://www.tate.org.uk/art/art-terms/s/still-life>
Do not print a biography from the first search result. Look, then write.

Key words

describe · analyse · interpret · evaluate · respond · paraphrase · strategy

Chapter 5 - Composition development

Before producing your final outcome, create several thumbnail sketches.

A thumbnail is a small, quick composition study.

Produce alternatives rather than trying to find the perfect composition immediately.

Experiment with cropping, scale, viewpoint, overlapping, negative space, focal point, light and arrangement.

Compare your thumbnails.

Ask: Which composition communicates my intention most effectively?

Your final composition should be the result of decision-making, not simply the first arrangement you happened to draw.

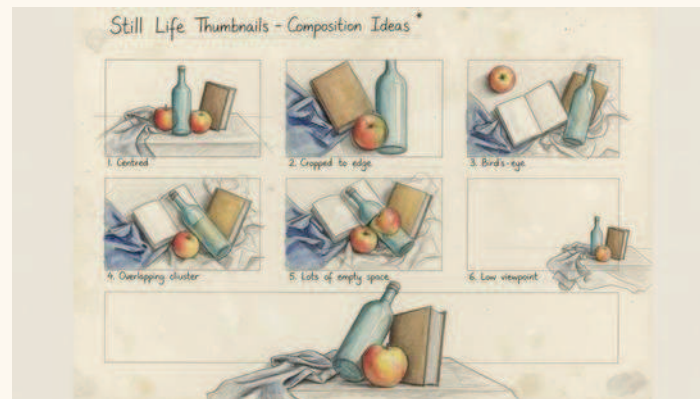


IMAGE 9.1.10 - Thumbnail compositions. Purpose: the same objects tested as centred, cropped, bird's-eye, overlapping, empty-field and low viewpoint.

Practical task: eight thumbnails, one winner

Make eight thumbnails of your still life, each genuinely different. Circle two. Ask a partner which one they read first. Keep the right to disagree.

eight thumbnails · circle two · partner note

Think like an artist

If all eight thumbnails look like the same idea with the bottle moved 1 cm, you have not experimented. Change viewpoint, crop or light, not only furniture.

Key words

thumbnail · crop · focal point · viewpoint · intention

Chapter 6 - Final still life outcome

You will now produce a sustained still life artwork.

Use your previous studies and experiments as preparation.

Your final outcome should demonstrate:

- careful observation

- considered composition
- effective use of visual elements
- technical control
- experimentation
- development from earlier studies
- personal decision-making

Do not rush towards the final piece.

Artists often spend considerable time preparing before beginning a final artwork.



IMAGE 9.1.11 - A sustained still life. Purpose: a finished original painting with considered empty space and side light.

A possible brief (your teacher may adapt it)

Title it. Give the work a title before you finish, even if you change the title later. Titles are part of communication.

Limit something. Two colours plus graphite. Or three objects only. Or one light source. Limits make decisions visible.

Keep the evidence. Photograph the set-up. Keep the thumbnails. The sketchbook should explain the painting.

Challenge: the object that does not belong

Add one object that seems not to fit (a phone, a tram ticket, a clay fragment). Make the composition hold it anyway. Still life can include the present tense.

final composition map: objects, light, title

Sustained work

Leave work flat to dry. Write your name on the back, not across the image. Photograph before you transport it. Do not stack wet paintings.

Key words

sustained outcome · intention · limitation · development

Chapter 7 - Review and project completion

When your artwork is complete, step away from it before evaluating it.

Consider:

- What worked well?
- Which decisions were successful?
- What did I learn?
- Which experiment influenced the final outcome?
- What would I change?
- Did the final artwork communicate my intention?

Peer assessment

When giving feedback, avoid simply saying: "I like it."

Instead, identify something specific.

For example: "The strong tonal contrast creates a clear focal point."

Or: "The cropped composition makes the objects feel more dramatic."

Useful feedback should help the artist make a decision.

Instead of	Try
"It's good."	"The empty space on the left makes the bottle feel isolated, which matches your title."
"I don't like the cloth."	"The cloth is competing with the bottle because both are the same mid-tone."
"You should add more colour."	"What would happen if you limited colour even further?"

End of Unit 9.1

My intention was _____.

The composition choice that carried it was _____.

The material that told the truth about the surface was _____.

If I had one more lesson I would _____.

unit review notes

What have I learned?

- [] I can explain why I chose these objects.
- [] I can name the composition decision I made.
- [] I can point to an experiment that changed the work.
- [] I can use at least four visual-element words accurately.
- [] I can give a peer a specific, useful comment.

Unit 9.2 - Identity

Identity is the way we understand ourselves and how we are represented by others.

It can involve personality, memories, family, culture, place, interests, experiences, relationships, possessions, appearance and emotions.

Artists have explored identity through portraits, self-portraits, objects, symbols, photographs, environments and abstract imagery.

A portrait does not have to show someone's face.

An object, colour, photograph or place can sometimes communicate something about a person more powerfully than a literal portrait.

Year 8 practised faces, proportion and clay heads. Year 9 asks a different question: how much of identity is visible, and how much is constructed?

On the identity desk today

A mirror, a pair of trainers, a camera, collage papers, a lump of clay, a sketchbook.

Your teacher says: "If I took your face out of the picture, what would still be you?"



IMAGE 9.2.01 - Identity studio. Purpose: set materials and mood for Unit 9.2: looking at people, objects and symbols.

In this unit you will

- gather a visual journal around identity
- photograph close-ups, shadows and partial views
- try realistic, expressive, partial and symbolic portraits
- use objects as stand-ins for a person
- experiment with collage, paint, photography and clay
- manipulate images through crop, repeat, enlarge and fragment
- study Frida Kahlo as a strategy of visual autobiography
- develop a personal outcome that is not a costume of another artist

Chapter 1 - Introduction to identity

Visible and hidden

Some parts of identity are easy to photograph: a face, a uniform, a hairstyle, a team shirt.

Some parts are not: a memory of a grandmother's kitchen in Cascais, a language you speak at home and not at school, a nickname you have outgrown, a future you have not told anyone.

Art can hold both.

Questions to consider:

- What makes you recognisable as an individual?
- Can an object represent a person?
- Can a photograph communicate personality?
- How much of identity is visible?

- How much is hidden?
- Can identity change?
- Can one person have multiple identities?

You might be a sibling at breakfast, a midfielder at lunch, a quiet drawer in Art, and a different person on the 15:40 train. None of those versions is fake. A Year 9 artwork can choose which version to show, and which to keep back.



IMAGE 9.2.02 - A portrait without a face. Purpose: trainers, backpack, headphones and sketchbook as a possible portrait.

Think like an artist

If someone who has never met you saw only five objects from your life, what would they get right, and what would they get wrong?

five objects / what they reveal / what they hide

Curiosity

The Portuguese-born painter Paula Rego (1935-2022) often staged identity as a story: figures, animals, furniture and childhood memory in the same room. A portrait can be a narrative, not a passport photo.

Watch me work one out

Tiago wants to make a self-portrait. He starts with a mirror drawing. It looks like a face he already knows. It does not feel like him.

He lists five things that would still be him if the face were missing: a swimming cap, a bus pass, his grandfather's watch, a page of maths working, a photograph of the river at Belém.

He photographs the watch at 10 cm, the bus pass in a hard shadow, and his own hand holding the cap. He collages those three with a small graphite study of his ear (not his whole face). The title is *Between two stops*.

The face is almost absent. The identity is not.

Key words

identity · representation · self-portrait · constructed identity · symbol

Chapter 2 - Image gathering

Begin building a visual journal around the theme of identity.

Collect photographs, observational drawings, objects, textures, patterns, places, colours, written words and personal visual references.

Photography can become an important part of your process.

Experiment with close-ups, unusual viewpoints, cropping, shadows, reflections, repetition, movement and partial views.

You do not need to photograph an entire person to communicate identity.

A hand, a pair of shoes, a room, a favourite object or a repeated gesture may be enough.



IMAGE 9.2.03 - A visual journal. Purpose: taped photographs, colour strips, drawings and notes as research, not as a finished scrapbook.



IMAGE 9.2.04 - Identity without a full face. Purpose: hand, shoes, a room, a silhouette as photographic starting points.

Photographing people

Ask before you photograph a classmate's face. Some people will say no, and that is a complete answer. Photograph hands, shoes, objects or your own reflection instead. Do not post studio photographs of other pupils online.

Practical task: twelve photographs, no full faces

Make twelve photographs that could belong to a project called Who I am when I am not posing. Close-ups, shadows, rooms, objects, gestures. Print or stick four into the sketchbook and annotate what each one might mean.

four photographs / four one-line annotations

Key words

visual journal · close-up · crop · reflection · viewpoint

Chapter 3 - Portrait and symbolic studies

Develop portrait studies using different approaches.

Explore realistic portraiture, expressive portraiture, distorted portraits, partial portraits, symbolic portraits, and portraits constructed from objects.



IMAGE 9.2.05 - Four approaches. Purpose: realistic study, expressive charcoal, partial crop, symbolic composite of the same invented student.

A realistic portrait is one kind of truth: the map of a face.

An expressive portrait is another: what it felt like to sit there.

A partial portrait can be more intimate than a full one, because the viewer has to come close.

A symbolic portrait uses stand-ins.

Symbols

A symbol is an image, object or visual element that represents an idea.

For example, an object might suggest memory, family, childhood, freedom, loss, ambition or belonging.

The meaning of a symbol can change depending on context.

A key on a ribbon can mean home, or a locker, or a secret. A football can mean joy or pressure. A plant can mean care. Context decides.

This is an important part of visual communication.



IMAGE 9.2.06 - Objects as symbols. Purpose: locket, ticket, plant, ball, sketchbook and glasses arranged as a possible portrait.

Practical task: two portraits of the same person

Make a realistic or observational study of a classmate (or of your own face in a mirror). Then make a second version that uses only objects, colours and fragments. Ask a partner which one feels more like the person.

left: observational · right: symbolic

Think like an artist

If a portrait is built from objects, who controls the meaning: the person who owns the objects, the artist who arranges them, or the viewer who reads them?

write your thinking

Key words

realistic · expressive · partial · symbolic · context

School activities and projects 1

Throughout the year, Art & Design may connect with wider school activities, events and interdisciplinary projects.

These projects may involve collaborative artworks, school displays, posters, photography, installations, visual communication, themed events and exhibitions.

You may be asked to adapt your artistic skills to a specific brief or audience.

This provides an opportunity to understand that art can function both as personal expression and public communication.

A corridor is not a sketchbook. People walk past. They will not read a 400-word statement. Your image has to work at walking speed.

On the shared table today

A real audience: other year groups, families, teachers. A real place: a noticeboard, a foyer, a window. Your teacher says: "Identity can be personal. It can also be ours. Decide which one this brief is."



IMAGE 9.2.07 - A school project table. Purpose: collaboration, posters, cameras and more than one pair of hands.

Read the live brief your teacher gives. Typical Year 9 examples:

- a photographic alphabet of the school
- a display for a languages evening: identity in more than one language
- portraits of "who we are" that do not only show faces
- a window of objects collected from a year group, labelled with care

Ask: Who is left out if we only use one language, one sport, or one idea of "normal"?

Public work

Do not identify a classmate in a public display without their agreement. Credit everyone who made the work. Do not block fire exits. Photograph the install before it is taken down.

Chapter 4 - Media experimentation

Identity can be explored through different media.

Consider how the physical qualities of a material contribute to the meaning of the work.

Torn paper can feel like memory. Wet clay can feel like a face being made. A photograph can feel like evidence. Thick paint can feel like a mood you cannot name.

Collage

Combine photographs, magazine images, drawings, text, textures and found materials.

Collage is a useful identity medium because identity is already layered. You can show the join.



IMAGE 9.2.08 - Identity as collage. Purpose: layered photographs, fabric and drawing as a constructed person.

Paint

Explore colour as an emotional and symbolic tool.

The same face in a cold blue-grey is not the same person as the same face in terracotta and gold. Colour is not decoration. It is a decision about feeling.



IMAGE 9.2.09 - Colour as emotion. Purpose: two painted heads of the same invented sitter in cold and warm palettes.

Photography

Use cropping, lighting and viewpoint to alter meaning.

A face lit from below is not the same character as a face lit from a window. A crop through the eyes can feel closer than a full figure.

Clay

Explore identity through masks, faces, objects, fragments and symbolic forms.

A fragment can be enough. A mask can hide and reveal at the same time. Year 8 made portrait heads. Year 9 can make the piece that is not the whole face.



IMAGE 9.2.10 - Clay mask and fragment. Purpose: three-dimensional identity without a complete portrait head.

Practical task: material as meaning

Make two small identity studies of the same idea, in two different media (for example collage and clay, or paint and photograph). Which material told the truth more clearly? Why?

two media / one identity idea

Clay and collage

Clay on a board, not on homework. Keep clay out of sinks. Magazines used for collage should be ones you are allowed to cut. Do not cut books from the library.

Key words

collage · palette · crop · fragment · mask

Chapter 5 - Image manipulation

An existing image can become the starting point for something completely different.

Experiment with repetition, enlargement, cropping, rotation, overlap, layering, fragmentation and abstraction.

Pattern

Repeated images can transform the meaning of an original photograph. One trainer is a shoe. Twenty trainers in a grid might be about belonging, or about pressure to match.

Enlargement

When a small detail is enlarged, the viewer may no longer immediately recognise the original subject. A jumper becomes a landscape of knit. A fingerprint becomes a map.

Abstraction

Abstraction does not necessarily mean making an image completely unrecognisable.

It can involve simplifying, exaggerating or transforming reality.

Ask: At what point does an image stop representing the original subject and become something new?



IMAGE 9.2.11 - One photograph, six lives. Purpose: repeat, enlarge, crop, rotate, overlap and fragment the same starting image.

Practical task: break one photograph

Print or photocopy one of your identity photographs (or a drawing). Cut it. Repeat it. Enlarge a detail with a viewfinder. Make a new image that the original owner might not immediately recognise as theirs.

original · crop · repeat · fragment

Challenge: the edge of recognition

How little information can you leave and still have it feel like that person? Test on a partner who knows them.

Key words

repetition · enlargement · fragmentation · abstraction · recognition

Chapter 6 - Artist research and analysis

Frida Kahlo

Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) is particularly relevant to the theme of identity because her paintings frequently combine portraiture, personal experience, symbolism, objects, animals, clothing, landscape and references to her own life.

When studying Kahlo, consider how she transforms personal experiences into visual imagery.

Look carefully at facial expression, clothing, objects, animals, plants, background, colour, symbolism, scale and composition.

Do not focus only on what the symbols mean.

Ask how Kahlo constructs a visual world in which those symbols become meaningful.

She often places herself in the centre, looks out, and fills the space around her with things that belong to her story: plants, animals, medical experience, Mexican dress, landscape. The painting is not a selfie

with stickers. It is a world built so that a life can be seen.

Year 9 does not ask you to dress as Kahlo, paint a unibrow, or copy *The Two Fridas*. That is costume.

Year 9 asks you to borrow a strategy: visual autobiography. Your symbols will be yours. Your clothes will be yours. Your story will be yours.



IMAGE 9.2.12 - Visual autobiography as a strategy. Purpose: an original contemporary symbolic portrait. Not a copy of Kahlo and not a likeness of Kahlo.

Other strategies you might pair with Kahlo

Artist	Strategy
Yinka Shonibare (b. 1962)	Patterned cloth as a complicated identity: Dutch wax prints, colonial history, and play.
Amy Sherald (b. 1973)	Skin painted in grisaille; clothing carries the colour and the personhood.
Njideka Akunyili Crosby (b. 1983)	Photo-transfer and painting: two places (Nigeria and the United States) in one room.
Cindy Sherman (b. 1954)	Identity as a role you put on. Useful if you photograph yourself as a character, carefully and with consent.
Kehinde Wiley (b. 1977)	Contemporary sitters given the scale and pattern of historical portraits. Power is a composition choice.
Paula Rego (1935-2022)	Story, memory and uncomfortable fairy tales. Identity as a scene you stage.

Look further (ask a teacher or family adult)

Tate Modern on Kahlo (exhibition and context):

<https://www.tate.org.uk/whats-on/tate-modern/frida-kahlo-the-making-of-an-icon>

Look at one work slowly. Write what you can see before you write what you have heard.

Your response

Create a personal response inspired by one aspect of Kahlo's practice.

You might explore symbolic objects, personal experiences, visual autobiography, repeated imagery, symbolic colour, or combining portraiture with objects.

Your work should not imitate Kahlo.

Instead, use her work as a starting point for your own investigation.

Practical task: a world around a person

Draw or collage yourself (or an invented sitter) surrounded by five objects that belong to a real life. Change the scale of one object until it feels like a symbol, not a prop.

sitter + five symbols + one change of scale

Key words

visual autobiography · symbolism · strategy · grisaille · photo-transfer

Chapter 7 - Composition planning

Develop several thumbnail compositions.

Experiment with portrait placement, scale, cropping, symbolic objects, pattern, background and negative space.

Discuss your ideas with a partner.

Ask your peer:

- What do you think this image communicates?
- Which part attracts your attention first?
- What could be developed further?
- Is the symbolism clear?
- Is there anything unnecessary?

Use feedback selectively.

You are the artist, so the final decision remains yours.

Practical task: five different ideas

Make five thumbnails that are not the same face with the objects shuffled. Change crop, scale, viewpoint or whether the face appears at all.

five identity thumbnails · peer note

Chapter 8 - Final outcome development

Develop your final identity artwork through sustained practical work.

Your final outcome should show evidence of research, experimentation, development, personal meaning, technical decisions and refinement.

The final artwork should feel connected to your preparatory work without simply repeating it.



IMAGE 9.2.13 - A sustained identity outcome. Purpose: mixed media, partial portrait and symbolic objects as a finished student work.

Possible forms (choose with your teacher):

- a mixed-media self-portrait with objects
- a series of three photographs
- a clay mask plus a drawing
- a collage that contains a drawing
- a painting that refuses a full face

Challenge: more than one identity in one image

Can the work hold two versions of a person without splitting into a cartoon "good side / bad side"? Overlap, transparency and crop are more interesting than a line down the middle.

final composition map and title

Chapter 9 - Review and project completion

Evaluate both the artwork and the process.

Consider:

- What did I discover about identity?
- Which visual symbols did I use, and why?
- Which artist influenced my thinking?
- Which material was most effective?

- Did my experiments change my original idea?
- What would I develop if I continued the project?

Remember that reflection is part of making art.

End of Unit 9.2

The part of identity I chose to show was _____.

The part I chose to keep back was _____.

The artist strategy I borrowed was _____.

If a stranger saw this work they might think _____.

unit review notes

What have I learned?

- [] I can explain identity as more than a face.
- [] I have a visual journal with photographs and notes.
- [] I tried more than one portrait approach.
- [] I can name a Kahlo strategy I used, without imitating her.
- [] I can talk about a symbol in context, not as a dictionary definition.

Unit 9.3 - On the Surface / Contained

The theme On the Surface / Contained can be interpreted in many different ways.

"Surface" can refer to skin, walls, water, fabric, objects, architecture, natural materials, photographs and textures.

"Contained" can refer to objects inside containers, enclosed spaces, boundaries, hidden information, emotions, memories, physical confinement, and things that are protected or concealed.

The strength of this project lies in the fact that the theme is open to interpretation.

Year 9 is ready for an open theme. You are no longer only answering "draw this bottle". You are answering "what do I think this theme is about?" and then proving it in materials.

On the texture desk today

A peeling wall, a glass jar, a closed box, a camera, ink, collage papers.

Your teacher says: "Something is visible. Something is not. Make an image that knows both facts."



IMAGE 9.3.01 - Surface and contained. Purpose: peeling paint, rust, cracked earth, a jar, a box and a doorway as starting points for the theme.

In this unit you will

- interpret an open theme without grabbing the first obvious idea
- build mind maps and mood boards that have atmosphere
- record surfaces through photography and observational drawing
- research artists who use texture, layering, boxes and negative space
- combine print, collage and mixed media
- push an image towards abstraction
- develop a sustained outcome that still belongs to your sketchbook

Chapter 1 - Theme introduction

Conceptual questions

- What is visible on the surface?
- What might exist underneath?
- Does the surface reveal or conceal?
- Can something be contained without being physically enclosed?
- Can emotions be contained?
- Can an image suggest something hidden without showing it?

A wall can be a surface (paint, crack, graffiti) and a container (a room behind it).

Skin can be a surface and a container.

A photograph is a surface that contains time.

A secret is contained without a box.

Do not stop at the first obvious ideas.

For example, "contained" might lead from: container → box → room → house → body → memory → emotion → secrecy.

Think like an artist

Write two opposite interpretations of the same photograph of a closed door: one in which the door protects, one in which it imprisons. The photograph has not changed. Your reading has.

one door / two readings

Watch me work one out

Mariana's first mind map for CONTAINED says: box, jar, suitcase, locker.

Too obvious. She keeps writing: locker → school bag → a voice you do not use in class → a language spoken only at dinner → a photograph in a wallet.

She photographs the inside of her locker through a 2 cm gap, then the peeling paint on the locker door, then a folded note (hers) in a jar. The mood board is rust, cream, one strip of gold from the note.

The final idea is not "a pretty box". It is what a gap lets you see.

Key words

surface · contained · reveal · conceal · interpretation · open theme

Chapter 2 - Mind maps and mood boards

Begin by exploring the theme visually.

Create a mind map containing different interpretations of SURFACE and CONTAINED.

A mood board should communicate an atmosphere as well as a subject.

Collect images based on colour, texture, shape, atmosphere, visual rhythm and material.

A mood board that is only "pictures of boxes" is a catalogue. A mood board that is sage, rust, cracked plaster, a jar of cloth and a half-open door is an atmosphere. Year 9 mood boards should feel like a place you could walk into.



IMAGE 9.3.02 - A mood board with atmosphere. Purpose: colour, texture samples and photographs pinned as a climate, not a shopping list.

Practical task: two maps, one board

Make a mind map for SURFACE and a mind map for CONTAINED. Circle three ideas that are not the first ones you wrote. Build a mood board (digital or paper) that could belong to those three ideas. Title the board with a feeling word, not a noun.

mind map extracts + mood-board thumbnail

Key words

mind map · mood board · atmosphere · visual rhythm

Chapter 3 - Visual recording

Use photography and observational studies to investigate surfaces and enclosed spaces.

Photograph cracks, peeling paint, reflections, fabric, rust, glass, shadows, containers, architectural details and natural textures.

Experiment with extreme close-ups.

A close-up can transform an ordinary surface into an abstract image.

Observation

Record surfaces using pencil, charcoal, ink, paint, pastel and photography.

Try to communicate the physical qualities of the surface rather than merely describing the object.

The job is not "this is a wall". The job is "this wall is dry, layered, wounded, repaired".



IMAGE 9.3.03 - Extreme close-up. Purpose: cracked plaster, rust, weave and water as images that almost forget their names.



IMAGE 9.3.04 - Recording a surface. Purpose: photograph and graphite study of the same peeling paint and jar.

Practical task: the 10 cm square

Use a viewfinder or your hands to isolate a 10 cm square of a real surface (wall, bag, tree, pavement). Photograph it. Draw it larger than life. Title it without using the object's name.

close-up square · drawing · title without the object's name

Photography around school

Stay in permitted areas. Do not photograph people without consent. Do not stand in roads, on furniture or in fire exits for "a better angle".

Key words

close-up · abstraction · rubbing · viewfinder · scale

Chapter 4 - Artist research

Study artists who use surface, texture, layering, abstraction, containment or emotional interpretation.

When researching, ask:

- What materials does the artist use?
- How important is texture?
- Is the surface smooth or disrupted?
- Are layers visible?
- What is hidden?
- What is revealed?
- How does the artwork create atmosphere?
- Does the physical surface of the artwork contribute to its meaning?

Remember that the material itself can become part of the message.

Artist	Strategy
Rachel Whiteread (b. 1963)	Cast the inside of spaces. House (1993) made the air of a home solid. Contained space becomes an object.
Joseph Cornell (1903-1972)	Wooden boxes of found objects: worlds you can look into but not enter.
El Anatsui (b. 1944)	Bottle tops and metal fragments woven into hanging cloths. Waste becomes a glittering surface of history.
Do Ho Suh (b. 1962)	Homes remade in translucent fabric. You can see through a room. Memory is a tent.
Aaron Siskind (1903-1991)	Photographs of walls that read as abstract paintings. Close-up as a way of thinking.
Antoni Tàpies (1923-2012)	Matter paintings: sand, marble dust, graffiti, walls as skin.
Cornelia Parker (b. 1956)	Cold Dark Matter (1991): a shed exploded and hung. Containment after it has failed.



IMAGE 9.3.05 - Four surface / contained strategies. Purpose: original teaching versions of a cast interior, a memory box, a fabric room and a woven fragment surface.

Curiosity

Rachel Whiteread's House stood on a London street for a few months in 1993: a white cast of a Victorian interior, the building around it gone. Neighbours argued. Then it was demolished. An artwork about memory can itself become a memory.

Practical task: borrow one quality

Choose one quality (cast of an inside, box as world, translucent room, close-up wall, exploded arrangement). Make a 20-minute experiment with your materials that uses that quality. Annotate the strategy in one sentence.

one borrowed quality / one experiment

Look further (ask a teacher or family adult)

Tate artist page for Rachel Whiteread: <https://www.tate.org.uk/art/artists/rachel-whiteread-2319>

Look at how a sculpture can be a surface and a container.

Key words

cast · assemblage · matter painting · negative space · found object

School activities and projects 2

Use this stage of the course for collaborative or school-based creative projects.

You may work individually or collectively on a project connected to school identity, an exhibition, an event, a wider theme or interdisciplinary learning.

You should apply the skills developed during the course while responding to a real audience or purpose.

A science corridor about materials, a humanities display about borders, a music evening about "what is held in a song": all of these are surface / contained briefs if you read them visually.

Photograph the place where the work will live. Scale is a design decision. A 10 cm collage that worked in your sketchbook may vanish on a 4-metre wall.

Install

Share ladders only with permission. Use the hanging system your teacher approves. Nothing over fire extinguishers. Label with the group name.

Chapter 5 - Media exploration

Experiment with processes that allow surfaces to be constructed, disrupted or layered.

Printmaking

Explore repeated marks, texture, positive and negative shapes, layering and accidental effects.

A ghost print (the faint second print) is often more interesting than the first. Accidents are information.

Collage

Combine different surfaces to create visual relationships.

Think about transparency, overlap, fragmentation, contrast and repetition.

Mixed media

Combine processes rather than treating them as separate exercises.

For example: photograph → print → collage → paint → drawing.

The objective is to discover what happens when one process changes another.

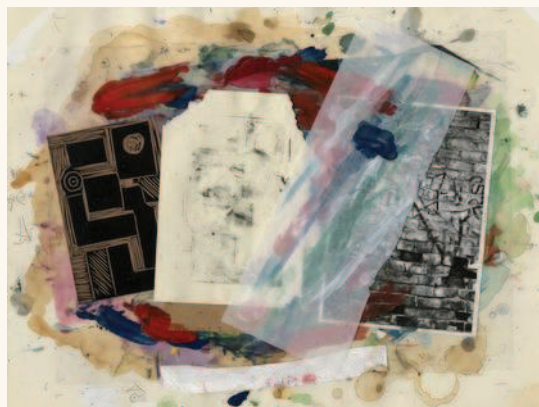


IMAGE 9.3.06 - Process changing process. Purpose: inked block, print, collage and paint on the same table as a sequence, not as separate hobbies.

Practical task: a chain of processes

Start with a photograph or rubbing of a surface. Print from it or over it. Collage. Paint. Draw back in. Stop after five stages. Photograph each stage if you can. Which stage was the real work?

stage 1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5

Print and collage

Roller ink stays on the slab, not on chairs. Wear an apron. Wash tools before ink skins over. Keep small bits of paper off the floor (they become skating rinks).

Key words

print · ghost print · overlay · transparency · mixed media

Chapter 6 - Image development

Develop your strongest visual experiments.

Explore pattern, repetition, abstraction, enlargement, cropping, distortion, layering and transparency.

Consider what happens when a recognisable image becomes increasingly abstract.

Can the viewer still sense the original image?

Does it matter if they cannot?

Year 9 abstraction is not "making a mess on purpose". It is removing or transforming information until the remaining marks still have a reason.

Think like an artist

If nobody can tell that your painting began as a photograph of a school locker, has the work failed? Or has it become about containment in a more interesting way? Argue both sides.

write both sides of the argument

Chapter 7 - Composition planning

Create thumbnail studies for your final outcome.

Think carefully about scale, focal point, rhythm, balance, contrast, repetition, empty space and layers. At least some of your compositions should be deliberately different from one another. Do not make five versions of essentially the same idea. Instead, challenge yourself to explore different possibilities.

Practical task: five unlike thumbnails

One should be almost empty. One should be densely layered. One should be a close-up. One should be a box or frame inside the page. One should break your own habit.

five unlike thumbnails

Chapter 8 - Final outcome development

Develop your chosen composition into a sustained final artwork.

Your final outcome should demonstrate the journey from:

theme → research → observation → experimentation → development → refinement → final outcome

The final artwork should not appear disconnected from your sketchbook.

Your preparation should be visible in the decisions you make.

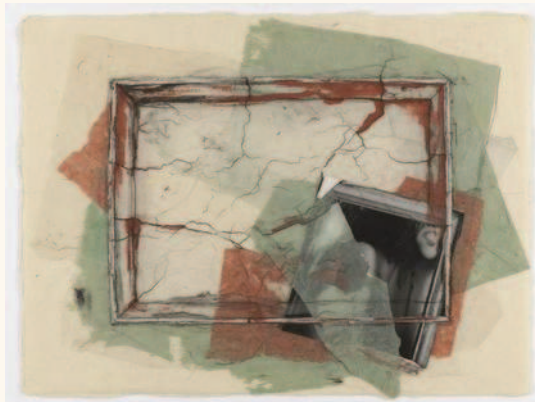


IMAGE 9.3.07 - A layered final outcome. Purpose: mixed media in which something is visible and something remains hidden.

Possible forms:

- a mixed-media panel with a hidden photograph
- a box construction
- a large close-up painting
- a print series of one surface
- a fabric or paper "room"

Challenge: hide something on purpose

Include one element that is almost invisible: a photograph under tissue, a word under paint, an object inside a box with a small aperture. Ask a partner whether they found it, and whether they needed to.

final map: what is visible / what is hidden

Chapter 9 - Review and project completion

Evaluate the project.

Ask:

- How did I interpret the theme?
- Did my interpretation change?
- Which surface qualities were most successful?
- How did experimentation influence the final artwork?
- Which materials worked best together?
- What is visible?
- What is hidden?
- What meaning might a viewer take from the work?

Compare your original mind map with the finished piece.

Has your understanding of the theme changed?

End of Unit 9.3

My first idea of the theme was _____.

My later idea was _____.

The surface quality that carried the work was _____.

What remains hidden, on purpose, is _____.

unit review notes

What have I learned?

- [] I can interpret an open theme in more than one way.
- [] I recorded real surfaces, not only imagined ones.
- [] I can name an artist strategy I used.
- [] I let one process change another.
- [] I can say what is visible and what is hidden in the final work.

Unit 9.4 - Exhibition

An exhibition is not simply a collection of artworks.

It is a curated experience.

Curating means making decisions about what should be shown, how it should be shown and how different works relate to one another.

Year 9 ends in public. Even a classroom wall is public. You are no longer only making. You are choosing, sequencing and speaking for the work.

On the gallery wall today

Work from still life, identity and surface. More pieces than will fit. A roll of labels. A tape measure.

Your teacher says: "If you can only hang seven things, which seven tell the truth about your year?"



IMAGE 9.4.01 - A school exhibition. Purpose: work hung at a consistent height, even spacing, labels, a place to stand.

In this unit you will

- select work as a curator, not as a hoarder
- review the sketchbook as a story of thinking
- plan height, spacing, sequence and lighting
- write an artist statement that does not describe the obvious
- work professionally on a school or public brief
- reflect on the whole of Year 9

Chapter 1 - Selection of work

Review your Year 9 portfolio.

Consider:

- Which works demonstrate your strongest ideas?
- Which show technical development?
- Which show experimentation?
- Which demonstrate personal expression?
- Which are visually connected?
- Which works show progress?

Do not automatically choose only your most polished artworks.

A sketch, experiment or failed attempt may sometimes be valuable because it demonstrates an important stage in your development.

Curators cut. That is the job. A wall of everything is a storeroom.

Practical task: the cut

Lay out twelve pieces (or photographs of them). Remove five. Write one sentence for each piece you kept: what job it does in the group. If two pieces do the same job, keep the stronger one.

kept / cut / the job each keeper does

Think like an artist

Would you hang a failed experiment next to a finished painting? When would that be honest, and when would it be noise?

write your thinking

Watch me work one out

João wants to hang his ten best pieces. The wall will take seven.

He spreads photographs on a table. Three still-life studies do the same job (they all say "I can shade a bottle"). He keeps the cropped one with the key, because it is the only one with a title that still works.

He hangs: 1 research page, 2 the cropped still life, 3 a failed pastel that taught him about glass, 4-5 identity pair, 6 surface close-up, 7 statement.

The failed pastel stays. It is not decoration. It is evidence of a decision.

Key words

curate · select · sequence · portfolio · evidence

Chapter 2 - Portfolio review

Look back through your sketchbook from the beginning of the year.

Identify evidence of:

Experimentation. Did you try different materials and approaches?

Development. Did your ideas change and become more sophisticated?

Decision-making. Can you explain why you made particular choices?

Refinement. Did you improve your work after receiving feedback?

Reflection. Can you identify what you learned?

A strong portfolio tells the story of your artistic development.



IMAGE 9.4.02 - A working portfolio. Purpose: selected pages, photographs, a clay record and a statement kept together.

Question	Evidence I can point to
Where did I take a risk?	
Where did a failure teach me something?	
Where did an artist change my plan?	
Where did I become more independent?	

Practical task: five pages that tell the year

Choose five sketchbook pages that, in order, could explain Year 9 to someone who was not there. Photograph them. This sequence is already a small exhibition.

five pages / why this order

Key words

experimentation · development · refinement · reflection · independence

Chapter 3 - Presentation planning

Think about how the artwork will be displayed.

Consider height, spacing, sequence, scale, grouping, lighting, labels, colour relationships and viewer movement.

Two artworks can look completely different depending on how they are presented.

Display arrangement

Experiment with different arrangements.

Chronological arrangement shows development over time.

Thematic arrangement groups works according to ideas.

Visual arrangement groups works according to colour, shape, scale or material.

Which arrangement communicates your work most effectively?



IMAGE 9.4.03 - Three ways to hang. Purpose: chronological row, thematic cluster, visual hang by colour.

A practical starting height for the centre of a work on a school wall is often around 150 cm from the floor, but match the architecture you actually have. Align tops or centres. Mixing both looks accidental.

Space is part of the work. If two pieces touch, they become one piece whether you meant them to or not.



IMAGE 9.4.04 - Labels and a hanging plan. Purpose: measured wall, small cards, tools of a careful install.

Labels

A school label can be short:

Inês Costa, Year 9. Still life with key, 2026. Gouache on paper.

Do not write your life story on the wall. That belongs in the statement, or in the sketchbook.

Install

Measure twice. Use the adhesive your teacher approves. Do not use packing tape on painted walls. Have a pair of hands for large work. Photograph the wall before and after.

Practical task: a paper hang

Print or sketch thumbnails of your selected work. Arrange them on a table as if the table were the wall. Photograph three different hangs. Choose one and draw a simple measured plan.

three hangs · chosen plan

Key words

hang · spacing · eye-level · label · viewer movement

Chapter 4 - Artist statement

An artist statement explains the thinking behind your work.

It should not simply describe what the viewer can already see.

A useful artist statement may explain:

- what your project explored
- why you chose the theme
- what influenced you
- which materials you used
- how your ideas developed
- what you wanted the viewer to experience
- what you learned

Questions to help you write

What was my starting point?

What did I investigate?

Which artists influenced my thinking?

What materials and processes did I explore?

What changed during the project?

What am I communicating?

What do I want the viewer to notice or question?

Keep the language clear and personal.

An artist statement should sound like the artist, not like a dictionary.

Weak: "In this project I used mixed media to explore identity in a unique and creative way."

Stronger: "I started with photographs of my grandmother's locket and ended with a collage that hides her face under tissue. I wanted the viewer to come close. Kahlo's idea of a world of objects around a person helped, but the objects are mine."

Aim for 80 to 150 words for a Year 9 wall. Longer statements belong in the sketchbook.

Practical task: 120 words

Write a statement for one body of work. Then cut 30 words. Read it aloud to a partner. If they can already see a sentence in the artwork, cut that sentence.

artist statement draft

Key words

artist statement · intention · audience · voice

School activities and projects 3

The final school projects provide an opportunity to apply the skills developed throughout the year in a public or collaborative context.

Depending on the school programme, this may involve preparing an exhibition, producing work for a school event, a collaborative installation, photography projects, display design, visual communication or interdisciplinary projects.

You should approach these projects professionally.

Think about the audience, purpose, context and practical requirements.

A professional attitude in Year 9 looks like this:

- you arrive with work labelled on the back
- you know which piece hangs beside which
- you have spare Blu Tack or the school's hanging system ready
- you can explain the work in two sentences to a visitor who is not an art teacher
- you help take the exhibition down as carefully as you put it up

Look further (ask a teacher or family adult)

If you can visit a museum in Lisbon, start with the Centro de Arte Moderna Gulbenkian:
<https://gulbenkian.pt/cam/en/>

Notice height, space and the order of rooms. That visit is research for your own wall.

Year 9 - Final reflection

At the end of Year 9, look back at your work as a whole.

You have explored observation, still life, portraiture, identity, symbolism, photography, collage, painting, printmaking, mixed media, abstraction, composition, artist research, visual communication, exhibition and presentation.

But the most important development is not simply the number of techniques you have learned.

It is your ability to think through making.

Artists often discover what they want to say by experimenting rather than knowing the answer before they begin.

Your sketchbook should therefore show not only what you can do, but how you think.

Questions for your final reflection

1. Which project was most meaningful to you?
2. Which material allowed you to express your ideas most effectively?
3. Which artist influenced you the most?
4. Which experiment changed your original idea?
5. What did you learn from an unsuccessful attempt?
6. How has your observational drawing developed?
7. How has your understanding of composition changed?
8. Are you more confident in making independent decisions?
9. How has your understanding of art changed since the beginning of the year?
10. What would you like to investigate next?

Looking forward

Art & Design is not about reaching a point where you know everything.

It is about becoming better at asking questions.

As you move towards more advanced Art & Design courses, you will be expected to develop increasingly personal ideas, take greater responsibility for your decisions and create work that communicates something meaningful.

The most important question is no longer: "Can I make this?"

It becomes: "Why do I want to make this, and how can I make the viewer understand it?"

That is the beginning of becoming an independent artist.

End of Year 9

The project that changed me was _____.

The question I will take into next year is _____.

Independence, for me, now means _____.

year reflection

Studio pages - Look, try, reflect

One studio sheet for each unit. Use it during the unit, not only at the end: it is your record of looking, making and deciding beside the teaching chapters.

Each sheet gives you a learning focus, success criteria, a timed task, a large working box, a five-step looking-notes table and an exit ticket. If you run out of space, continue in the sketchbook and tape a thumbnail onto the sheet.

The sheets do not replace your sketchbook. They keep evidence of the decisions you made while the work was in progress.

What is in this section

Studio sheets

One per unit: 9.1 Still Life, 9.2 Identity, 9.3 On the Surface / Contained, 9.4 Exhibition.

Techniques

Five reference pages: watercolour, block print, monoprint, collage and acrylic painting. Each has materials, basic instructions, ways of working and advice on looking after your images.

How to use a studio sheet

1. Read the learning focus before you start. It is what this unit is about.
2. Tick the success criteria honestly at the end, not during.
3. Time the timed task. Stop when the time is up.
4. Fill the looking-notes table using the five steps: describe, analyse, interpret, evaluate, respond.
5. Finish with the exit ticket: one sentence for each line.

Techniques reference

1. Techniques 1 - Watercolour
2. Techniques 2 - Block print
3. Techniques 3 - Monoprint
4. Techniques 4 - Collage
5. Techniques 5 - Acrylic painting

Each technique page lists the materials you need, the basic instructions, two or three ways of working with it, and how to look after the images you make.

Unit 9.1 studio page - Still Life

Unit 9.1. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Choose objects for meaning, then arrange them so a title could exist.

Success criteria

- I looked more than I copied.
- I can name one visual element I used on purpose.
- I can name one principle of design I used on purpose.
- I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed task

Work from today's demonstration. Keep the focus in view: choose objects for meaning, then arrange them so a title could exist.

On this page

Unit 9.1: still life

Looking notes (DESCRIBE / ANALYSE / INTERPRET / EVALUATE / RESPOND)

Describe

Analyse

Interpret

Evaluate

Respond

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 9.2 studio page - Identity

Unit 9.2. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Show who you are through what you choose to include, alter or hide.

Success criteria

- I gathered images from more than one source.
- I experimented with at least two ways of combining them.
- I can name an artist strategy I borrowed and how I made it mine.
- My final image says something about me, not only about the artist.
- I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed task

Work from today's demonstration. Keep the focus in view: show identity through choice, symbol and change.

On this page

Unit 9.2: identity

Looking notes (DESCRIBE / ANALYSE / INTERPRET / EVALUATE / RESPOND)

Describe

Analyse

Interpret

Evaluate

Respond

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 9.3 studio page - On the Surface / Contained

Unit 9.3. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Turn a surface into an idea: what is shown, what is hidden, what is contained.

Success criteria

- I recorded close-up details, not only whole objects.
- I tested at least two materials or processes.
- I used layering, hiding or containing on purpose.
- I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed task

Work from today's demonstration. Keep the focus in view: surface, layer, hidden, contained.

On this page

Unit 9.3: surface / contained

Looking notes (DESCRIBE / ANALYSE / INTERPRET / EVALUATE / RESPOND)

Describe

Analyse

Interpret

Evaluate

Respond

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 9.4 studio page - Exhibition

Unit 9.4. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Select, present and explain work so an audience can read it.

Success criteria

- I selected work against a reason, not habit.
- I planned how the work is seen: order, spacing, height, light.
- I wrote an artist statement in plain sentences.
- I asked one person to read the exhibit and adjusted once.
- I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed task

Work from today's demonstration. Keep the focus in view: the exhibition is part of the artwork.

On this page

Unit 9.4: exhibition

Looking notes (DESCRIBE / ANALYSE / INTERPRET / EVALUATE / RESPOND)

Describe
Analyse
Interpret
Evaluate
Respond

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Techniques 1 - Watercolour

Transparent paint, water and control.

Materials

- Watercolour pans or tubes, one round brush (size 8 or 10) and a large flat wash brush
- Two pots of water: one for rinsing, one clean for mixing
- Cold-pressed (textured) paper, 200 gsm or heavier, taped flat to a board
- Kitchen towel for lifting colour and controlling drips

How to use it

1. Tape the paper flat. Draw lightly in pencil first if the composition needs it.
2. Mix more paint than you think you need, in a palette well, before touching the paper.
3. Work light to dark: pale washes first, strong colour last. Let each layer dry before the next.
4. Wash and dry the brush whenever you change colour.

How to look after the images you make

Label every study on the back or in the corner: date, materials, time taken and one sentence about what you learned. Keep flat work in a folder, not folded in a bag.

Photograph anything three-dimensional, shiny or fragile straight away, in daylight, with the artwork flat and the camera parallel to it. Scan or photograph prints before you glue them into the sketchbook, so a copy survives even if the original is damaged.

Keep your best result and your most interesting failure.



TECHNIQUE 1 - Flat wash, graded wash and wet-on-wet. Purpose: show control of water.

Ways of working

Wet-on-dry

Brush clean water onto dry paper, then touch colour into it. The colour blooms softly with fuzzy edges. Good for skies, backgrounds and mood studies. Control it by tilting the board and by how wet the paper is.

Graded wash

Load the flat brush, sweep one even band across the top, dip slightly, sweep again just below so the bands merge. Each band is paler than the last. Good for skies and simple backgrounds.

Wet-on-wet

Wet the whole area with clean water, then drop colour onto the wet surface so it spreads on its own. You steer it; you do not draw with it. Good for loose studies of clouds, water and soft shadows.

Techniques 2 - Block print

Carve a block, ink it, press it.

Materials

- Soft rubber or lino block, and gouges (V-blade for lines, U-blade for clearing)
- Water-based block-printing ink, a flat tray and a brayer (roller)
- Smooth paper for printing and newsprint for test pulls
- A wooden spoon or baren for rubbing the back of the paper

How to use it

1. Draw your design, then transfer it to the block in reverse: printed areas are what you leave raised.
2. Carve away everything that should stay the colour of the paper. Always carve away from your hand.
3. Roll a thin, even layer of ink on the tray until it sounds sticky, then roll it onto the block.
4. Lay the paper on top and rub firmly with the back of the spoon before peeling it back.

How to look after the images you make

Label every study on the back or in the corner: date, materials, time taken and one sentence about what you learned. Keep flat work in a folder, not folded in a bag.

Photograph anything three-dimensional, shiny or fragile straight away, in daylight, with the artwork flat and the camera parallel to it. Scan or photograph prints before you glue them into the sketchbook, so a copy survives even if the original is damaged.

Keep your best result and your most interesting failure.

Ways of working

Single-colour relief

One block, one colour. Every mark you carve becomes a white line; everything left raised prints as solid colour. Strong, graphic, and the safest way to learn the process. Print an edition of at least three identical pulls.

Reduction print

Print the whole edition in the palest colour first, then carve more away from the same block and print the next colour over it. Each step removes what you want to keep from the previous colour. Plan it on paper first: the block is destroyed as you go.

Two-block print

Carve a second block for a second colour (for example a background or a highlight) and print it in register on top of the first. Use small pencil registration marks so the layers line up.



TECHNIQUE 2 - Carving, inking and the finished print. Purpose: show the reversed image.

Techniques 3 - Monoprint

One drawing in ink, one print only.

Materials

- A flat, smooth plate: acrylic sheet, gel plate or a laminated card
- Water-based printing ink or slow-drying acrylic, rollers and cotton buds
- Paper, and a wooden spoon or press for even contact
- Cotton buds, rags, cocktail sticks and fingers for drawing tools

How to use it

1. Roll a thin, even layer of ink over the plate.
2. Draw directly into the ink with a cotton bud (adds a line) or add ink back with a fingertip (adds a mark).
3. Lay the paper over the plate and rub the back evenly with the spoon.
4. Peel the paper back in one confident movement. This pull is the artwork: it cannot be repeated.

How to look after the images you make

Label every study on the back or in the corner: date, materials, time taken and one sentence about what you learned. Keep flat work in a folder, not folded in a bag.

Photograph anything three-dimensional, shiny or fragile straight away, in daylight, with the artwork flat and the camera parallel to it. Scan or photograph prints before you glue them into the sketchbook, so a copy survives even if the original is damaged.

Keep your best result and your most interesting failure.

Ways of working

Subtractive (drawing back)

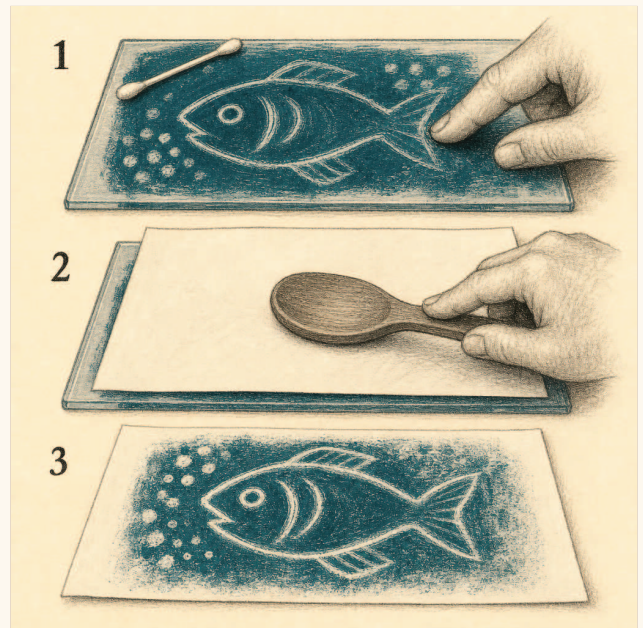
Roll ink over the whole plate, then remove the image by drawing into the ink with cotton buds and rags. The lines print as the colour of the paper. Fast and confident marks work best: hesitation shows.

Additive (drawing on)

Leave the plate clean and paint or roll the image directly onto it, then print. Allows colour and loose brushwork, but the ink must still be wet when you pull the print.

Ghost print

Without re-inking, print the plate a second time. The faint leftover image is called a ghost. Print it, then draw into it with pencil or pastel: many artists prefer the ghost to the first pull.



TECHNIQUE 3 - Drawing into the ink, pressing, pulling the single print. Purpose: show the ghost mark.

Techniques 4 - Collage

Cut, tear and layer paper into an image.

Materials

- A range of papers: cartridge, coloured, newsprint, magazine pages, tissue and corrugated card
- PVA glue or a glue stick, and a brush for spreading PVA thinly
- Scissors and a scalpel or craft knife with a cutting mat
- A background board or heavy paper to work on

How to use it

1. Gather more papers than you need. Sort them by colour, tone or texture.
2. Arrange and rearrange the pieces on the background before gluing anything.
3. Glue from the background forwards. Smooth each piece flat from the centre outwards.
4. Leave edges honest: torn edges read as soft, cut edges read as sharp.

How to look after the images you make

Label every study on the back or in the corner: date, materials, time taken and one sentence about what you learned. Keep flat work in a folder, not folded in a bag.

Photograph anything three-dimensional, shiny or fragile straight away, in daylight, with the artwork flat and the camera parallel to it. Scan or photograph prints before you glue them into the sketchbook, so a copy survives even if the original is damaged.

Keep your best result and your most interesting failure.

Ways of working

Torn-paper collage

Tear papers and let the white torn edges show. The torn edge is the point: it gives texture and shows the making. Work in tones of one colour for a study, or in full colour for a finished piece.

Layered and hidden

Glue layers with parts deliberately covered by the next layer. Reveal and conceal: a strip of magazine text, a corner of a photograph, a piece of card that lifts. The meaning sits in what you choose to hide.

Mixed-media collage

Combine collage with drawing and print: a monoprint as the base, torn paper on top, pencil or ink details added last. This is the natural bridge into the Unit 9.2 and 9.3 projects.



TECHNIQUE 4 - Selecting papers, layering and the finished collage.
Purpose: show torn and cut edges.

Techniques 5 - Acrylic painting

Opaque, fast-drying, forgiving.

Materials

- Acrylic paint in a small palette: titanium white, a red, a blue, a yellow and an earth tone
- Flat and round brushes, and a palette knife
- Cartridge paper, card or canvas board; keep brushes in water while you work
- A rag and a pot of water; acrylic dries fast and permanently

How to use it

1. Squeeze out only what you will use in the session: acrylic dries hard in an hour.
2. Mix colours on the palette, not on the artwork. Add a little water to thin; use it neat for full strength.
3. Block in the large shapes first, in their average colour. Details come last.
4. Wash brushes immediately after use with warm water and soap.

How to look after the images you make

Label every study on the back or in the corner: date, materials, time taken and one sentence about what you learned. Keep flat work in a folder, not folded in a bag.

Photograph anything three-dimensional, shiny or fragile straight away, in daylight, with the artwork flat and the camera parallel to it. Scan or photograph prints before you glue them into the sketchbook, so a copy survives even if the original is damaged.

Keep your best result and your most interesting failure.



TECHNIQUE 5 - Flat colour, impasto and painting over a dry layer.
Purpose: show opacity and body.

Ways of working

Opaque layering

Acrylic dries quickly and covers what is underneath. Build the painting in layers: dark ground first, big shapes next, lights and details on top. Mistakes can simply be painted over once dry.

Impasto

Apply thick, undiluted paint with a brush or palette knife so the marks stand up off the surface in ridges. Direction matters: every stroke stays visible. Good for texture studies and expressive surfaces.

Dry brush and scumbling

Wipe most of the paint off the brush, then drag it lightly across the texture of the surface. Broken colour shows through. Good for weathered surfaces, which links directly to Unit 9.3.

Appendix / Reference

These pages are a toolkit. Use them during every unit, not only at the end of the year.

A - Visual elements

The visual elements are the raw materials of looking and making. Year 7 introduced them. Year 8 asked you to choose them. Year 9 asks you to choose them because they communicate.

When you write about work, try: "I used tone to..." not "I used lots of things."

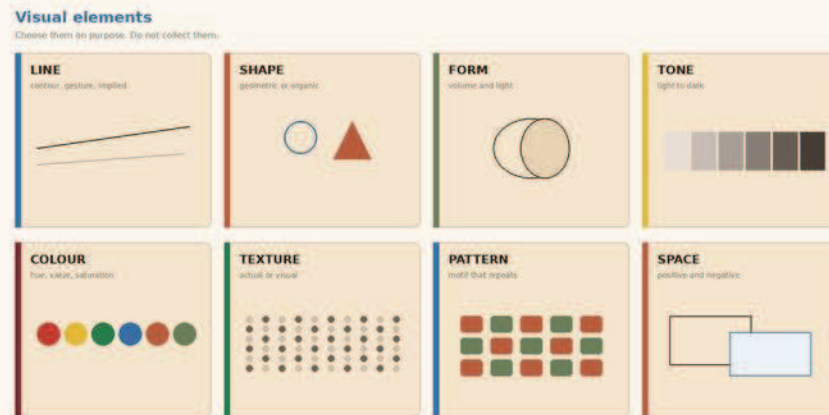


IMAGE A.01 - Visual elements board. Purpose: a quick map of line, shape, form, colour, tone, texture, pattern and space.

Line

A mark that connects two points, or the edge where two shapes meet.

Line can be contour (edge), gesture (action), or implied. Weight, speed and direction change feeling. In still life a cross-contour can wrap a bottle. In identity a continuous line can record looking without vanity.

Shape

A flat, enclosed area. Geometric or organic.

A bottle is a shape before it is glass. A cropped forehead is a shape. Negative shapes between objects often tell the truth of an arrangement.

Form

Shape with volume. Light on one side, shadow on the other.

Clay masks are form. A shaded lemon is form on paper. Drawing creates the illusion of form. Sculpture creates actual form.

Colour

Hue, value, saturation.

In identity work, colour is often a feeling before it is a local colour of skin or cloth. In still life, a limited palette can be more eloquent than a full rainbow.

Tone

The scale from light to dark, with or without hue.

If everything is mid-grey, nothing sits forward. Find the darkest dark and the lightest light before you decorate.

Texture

Tactile (real) or visual (drawn or photographed).

Year 9 surface work lives here: rust, peel, weave, dust. Mixed media can be texture, not only describe it.

Pattern

A motif that repeats.

Repeated photographs, window grids, a grid of objects (Milroy). Pattern can comfort or, if broken, can wake the eye.

Space

Positive (the thing) and negative (the air). Empty space is not wasted space if you chose it. A still life with a large field can feel like Morandi. A cropped identity photograph can feel like a secret.

Your turn: element hunt

Pick any artwork in this book. Name three visual elements doing the heavy lifting. Cover the caption with your hand first.

element hunt: artwork, three elements, one sentence each

B - Principles of design

If elements are ingredients, principles are recipes: how you organise the elements.

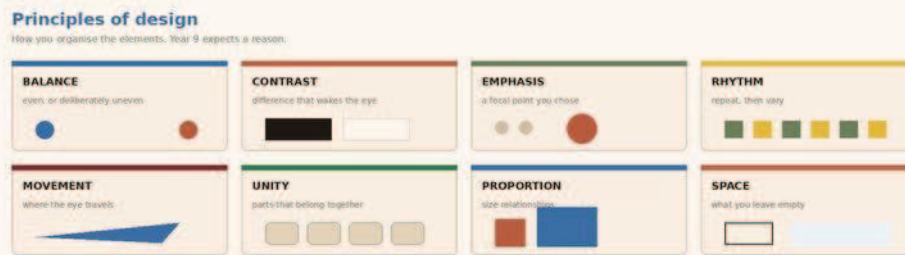


IMAGE B.01 - Principles of design board. Purpose: balance, contrast, emphasis, rhythm, movement, unity, proportion, space as visual diagrams.

Balance

Visual weight. Symmetrical balance feels stable. Asymmetrical balance can feel lively. A still life with all objects on the right needs a counterweight: a shadow, a title, or empty space used on purpose.

Contrast

Difference: light/dark, rough/smooth, huge/tiny.

Contrast creates emphasis. Two identity portraits in opposite palettes are a contrast experiment.

Emphasis

The focal point: where the eye lands first.

If you have three emphases, you have none.

Rhythm

Repetition with beat. Vary the beat so it does not lull.

Movement

How the eye travels through the work. Diagonals, pointing objects, a large form leading to a small one.

Unity

Do the parts belong together? Unity is not sameness. A mixed-media surface piece has unity if every layer has a job.

Proportion

Size relationships. Awkward proportion can be a mistake or a decision. Kahlo-like scale changes (a plant larger than a head) are proportion used as language.

Space (as a principle)

What you leave empty, and why.

Remember

Elements = what you use. Principles = how you organise. In critiques, try: "I used contrast of tone to create emphasis on the key."

C - Art & Design vocabulary

Glossary of key terms used throughout Year 9. British spellings.

Abstraction. Simplifying or departing from exact appearance while keeping a link to something seen or felt.

Artist statement. A short piece of writing that explains intention, process and decisions.

Assemblage. An artwork built from found objects, often in a box or on a surface.

Cast. A solid made from the inside or outside of something (a mould of a space or object).

Collage. Composing by cutting, tearing and combining existing images and papers.

Composition. The arrangement of visual elements in a space.

Contained. Held, enclosed, protected or hidden: objects, spaces, feelings.

Context. The situation that changes what a symbol or object means.

Crop. Where you cut the edge of an image; a viewpoint decision.

Curate. To select, sequence and present work for an audience.

Describe / analyse / interpret / evaluate / respond. Year 9 looking method.

Exhibition. A designed experience of looking, with a path, pauses and labels.

Fragment. A part shown as if it were enough.

Ghost print. A faint second print from leftover ink.

Grisaille. Painting in greys. Amy Sherald uses a related idea for skin.

Identity. The qualities that communicate who a person is, including what is hidden.

Intention. What you meant the work to do. Check it at the end.

Mixed media. More than one material used together on purpose.

Mood board. A collection of visual references used to set atmosphere and direction.

Negative space. The shapes of the gaps.

Observation. Drawing or recording from looking, not only from memory or a phone.

Portfolio. An edited, sequenced collection of work.

Refinement. Making deliberate adjustments to strengthen an artwork.

Still life. An artwork of objects that have been deliberately arranged.

Strategy. A way of working borrowed from an artist, not a copy of their picture.

Surface. The outer layer of a thing: paint, skin, rust, paper, photograph.

Symbol. An image or object that stands for an idea. Meaning depends on context.

Thumbnail. A tiny, fast composition sketch used to compare options.

Vanitas. A still-life tradition in which objects remind us of time and passing.

Viewpoint. Where the maker stands (or where the camera stands).

Visual autobiography. Telling a life through images, objects and symbols.

Visual journal. A collected set of photographs, drawings and notes around a theme.

Visual texture. Marks that make a surface look rough, smooth, shiny or soft.

Your turn: five words

Without looking back, define still life, symbol, curate, strategy and contained in one sentence each. Then check.

five definitions in your own words

D - Artists, designers and references

Short reference pages connected to the projects. These are starting points for research, not scripts to copy. Record the source you actually used (book, museum site, teacher print-out).

Named artists appear here as strategies. Plates in this book are original teaching illustrations, not reproductions of copyrighted paintings.

Still life (Unit 9.1)

Maker	Why look	Steal this, not the picture
Giorgio Morandi	bottles, intervals, muted colour	quiet repetition
Paul Cézanne	fruit built from planes	more than one viewpoint
Clara Peeters	breakfast pieces, metalware	the maker hidden in a reflection
Juan Sánchez Cotán	hanging vegetables, dark window	dramatic light, mathematical space
Michael Craig-Martin	outline everyday objects	colour as a decision, not local colour
Lisa Milroy	objects in grids	repetition as looking

Identity (Unit 9.2)

Maker	Why look	Steal this, not the picture
Frida Kahlo	self, objects, animals, story	visual autobiography
Paula Rego	staged scenes, memory	identity as a narrative
Yinka Shonibare	Dutch wax cloth, history	pattern as complicated belonging
Amy Sherald	grisaille skin, patterned clothes	colour as clothing, not as "accuracy"
Njideka Akunyili Crosby	photo-transfer rooms	two places in one picture
Kehinde Wiley	contemporary sitters, historic scale	power as composition

Surface / contained (Unit 9.3)

Maker	Why look	Steal this, not the picture
Rachel Whiteread	casts of interiors	the inside made solid
Joseph Cornell	boxes of found objects	a world you can look into
El Anatsui	bottle-top cloths	waste as glittering surface
Do Ho Suh	fabric homes	a room you can see through
Aaron Siskind	photographs of walls	close-up as abstraction
Cornelia Parker	exploded shed, hanging	containment after it fails

Exhibition (Unit 9.4)

Look at how museums hang work: height, space, sequence. A visit to CAM Gulbenkian in Lisbon is research, not a day off.

E - Assessment and success criteria

Teachers will adapt this grid to the school's assessment language. Pupils can use it as a self-check.

	Emerging	Secure	Independent
Looking	copies a symbol of the object	records relationships, light and surface	looks until the object becomes a decision
Experiment	tries one material once	tries several, keeps the failures	lets one process change another
Development	first idea = last idea	thumbnails exist	thumbnails change the outcome
Meaning	"it looks nice"	can name an intention	can test whether the viewer received it
Artist research	biography copy	names a quality	uses a strategy in new work
Independence	waits to be told	makes choices with support	can explain a change without being asked
Presentation	pile of work	labelled selection	curated sequence and a clear statement

Closed tasks in this book (checklists, one-word fills) have no single "answer key". The evidence is in the sketchbook.

Notes

Use these pages for leftover thumbnails, hanging plans, or a sentence you did not have time to write in the lesson.

Date: _____ Name: _____

notes / leftover thinking

notes / leftover thinking